

Network Delaware

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Strategic Nonviolence in Civic Education: Research Brief

I. Purpose and Scope

This brief reviews the research and evidence base for strategic nonviolence and leadership development as a component of K–12 civic education, with specific application to Network Delaware's framework's Front 4. It takes up four questions: What is strategic nonviolence as a civic education framework, and how does it differ from standard conflict resolution or anti-bullying programs? What does the evidence show about its effects on students, particularly those from the priority communities this framework serves? How have comparable frameworks incorporated this component, and what does the lack of a complete state model mean for Delaware? And what would a strategic nonviolence curriculum need to look like to genuinely serve Delaware's most vulnerable students rather than treating them as a problem to be managed?

No comparison state has codified strategic nonviolence and leadership development in statute or integrated it into a formal civic education framework. That gap is both the most pressing problem in the comparative field and the clearest opening for Delaware to lead. The evidence base for this investment is strong, but implementation models are still developing, which means the curriculum will need to be built through community co-design rather than borrowed from an existing template.

II. Defining Strategic Nonviolence in the Civic Education Context

Strategic nonviolence, as a civic education framework, is distinct from three commonly conflated concepts: conflict resolution, anti-bullying programming, and peaceful coexistence education. Conflict resolution addresses interpersonal disputes. Anti-bullying programming addresses harmful behaviors between individuals. Peaceful coexistence education aims at tolerance and mutual respect. Strategic nonviolence encompasses all of these and adds a political and structural dimension: it equips students to understand power, to engage with unjust systems through principled, purposeful action rather than avoidance or reactive escalation, and to build collective influence through disciplined strategic action.

The most relevant intellectual tradition to K–12 civic education is Kingian Nonviolence, the philosophy and methodology codified from the practice of the U.S. Civil Rights Movement and systematized in the curriculum co-authored by Dr. Bernard LaFayette, Jr. and David Jehnsen. The Kingian framework is organized around six principles: nonviolence as a way of life for courageous people; the Beloved Community as the goal; attack forces of evil, not persons doing evil; accept suffering without retaliation for the cause; avoid internal violence of spirit as well as external violence; and the universe is on the side of justice. These principles are not passive: they describe a disciplined, strategic approach to confronting injustice that requires preparation, skill, and collective organization. The curriculum has been implemented in schools, prisons, and community organizations nationally and internationally for approximately 50 years (CT Center for Nonviolence, 2025; Nonviolent Schools RI, 2025).

For the purposes of this framework, strategic nonviolence in civic education refers to a curriculum and practice model that integrates three components: (1) power literacy: the ability to analyze how power operates in systems and institutions, identify points of leverage, and understand the strategic logic of collective civic action; (2) conflict navigation: the skills to

engage constructively with institutional resistance, de-escalate confrontational dynamics, and sustain civic engagement in the face of hostility without abandoning the civic field; and (3) leadership development: the capacity to organize collectively, distribute roles, mentor others, and build civic multipliers who carry knowledge and capacity forward into families and communities.

III. Evidence Base: Effects on Students

A. Strategic Nonviolence and Civic Efficacy

Research on youth civic engagement consistently identifies civic efficacy (the belief that one's actions can produce real change) as the civic asset most strongly associated with political participation and social activism, particularly among youth of color experiencing marginalization (Wray-Lake et al., 2022; ScienceDirect). Studies using structural equation modeling with urban middle and high school samples have found that exposure to democratic practices, including organized civic action with decision-maker contact, produces significantly stronger civic efficacy gains among Black and Latino youth than among white youth, a finding that inverts the typical equity assumption that minority youth are less likely to benefit from civic programming (Cohen et al., PMC, 2017). The reason for this reversal lies in the power analysis component: for youth whose lived experience includes direct encounters with systemic injustice, civic education that names and addresses that injustice is far more credible and motivating than civic education that treats democratic institutions as neutral.

Research on civic assets among youth of color (Wray-Lake et al., 2022) also finds that critical reflection (the ability to identify structural inequities) does not convert into civic action on its own. Students who score high on critical reflection without accompanying civic efficacy

demonstrate lower civic action rates than those who have both. What this means for curriculum design is clear: strategic nonviolence education must build efficacy alongside analysis. A curriculum that develops students' ability to name oppression without building their capacity to engage with it strategically produces awareness without agency. For students who are already acutely aware of the conditions of their lives, that outcome is not just inadequate; it is actively discouraging.

B. Kingian Nonviolence in School Settings

A mixed-methods quasi-experimental study of the Kingian Nonviolence Conflict Reconciliation Training Program with high school students (Cyril, 2020, University of Rhode Island) found that the program was associated with improved social and cultural learning outcomes and reduced rates of violence among participants, and introduced the concept of cultural and emotional learning as a distinct outcome domain. The study used a pretest/posttest design with four one-month follow-up focus groups, providing stronger evidence than single-point assessments. The findings support the program's capacity to develop the social and emotional competencies that are preconditions for sustained civic engagement.

Nonviolent Schools RI, founded in 2018 by educator Robin Wildman following her direct training with Dr. Bernard LaFayette, Jr., implements the Kingian Nonviolence curriculum in Rhode Island schools with a focus on transforming school climate and culture toward an equitable, nonviolent learning environment. The organization trains educators, staff, administrators, and families, recognizing that school climate change requires a whole-school structural shift rather than a standalone curriculum add-on (Nonviolent Schools RI, 2025). Dr. LaFayette, who died on March 5, 2026, at the age of 85, following five decades of curriculum

development and training internationally, emphasized that Kingian Nonviolence is a philosophy and methodology providing knowledge, skills, and motivation for solving personal and community problems, a framing directly aligned with the civic capacity goals of the From Civic Learning to Civic Power framework.

C. Restorative Practices as a Civic Infrastructure

Restorative practices, a broader category that includes restorative justice circles, community conferencing, and peace-making processes, provide the institutional infrastructure within which strategic nonviolence skills can be practiced. A 2023 article in *Political and Legal Anthropology Review* (Winn, Sage Journals) argues from ethnographic data that restorative justice circles, when implemented with fidelity in schools, change interactional patterns in ways that generate group solidarity and individual emotional energy, precisely the social conditions required for collective civic action. Winn frames restorative justice practice as a space for civic education, where students practice the skills of active community stakeholders, reflective listeners, and leaders.

The CDC's public health guidance on restorative practices in schools (2024) documents that well-implemented restorative practices increase students' problem-solving and conflict resolution skills, reduce disciplinary disparities, reduce out-of-school suspensions, and improve overall school climate. Students of color and students with disabilities are suspended and expelled at disproportionately higher rates than other students; restorative practices directly reduce these disparities, removing a structural barrier to civic participation for the students this framework prioritizes. The research also notes an important implementation requirement: restorative practices take three to five years before producing observable effects on student outcomes, and

require whole-school structural commitment rather than isolated classroom implementation, a design requirement with direct implications for how Network Delaware structures its community partnerships.

A systematic review of restorative practices effectiveness (Frontiers in Education, 2025) found that the restorative approach contributes to significant reduction in school exclusion and inequalities of gender, race, and socioeconomic status, and that positive school relationships are associated with improved school engagement, achievement, and wellbeing. The review also confirms a research-to-practice gap: adoption of restorative practices has outpaced the available research, and implementation success requires teachers to undergo an internal belief-system transformation, not merely a skill acquisition. This reinforces the need for sustained professional development and school leadership commitment as preconditions for equitable outcomes.

IV. The Priority Community Case: Why Strategic Nonviolence Is Not Optional

The From Civic Learning to Civic Power framework's eight guiding principles include nonviolence as a strategy, discipline, and care, explicitly described as not passivity, but principled civic action. For the six priority communities this framework serves, strategic nonviolence is not an elective enrichment component; it is the difference between civic participation and civic exclusion.

Priority Community	Specific Strategic Nonviolence Need	Without It
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Black and Brown Youth	Students navigating schools with documented discipline disparities need the capacity to engage institutionally without triggering punitive responses. Strategic nonviolence equips them to register dissent, advocate for change, and navigate authority without escalation, skills with direct consequences for safety and academic persistence.	Civic education that teaches democratic ideals without equipping students to navigate the coercive realities of the institutions they inhabit is alienating rather than empowering. Critical consciousness without efficacy produces disengagement, not action (Wray-Lake et al., 2022).
Immigrant and Mixed-Status Youth	Students and families whose access to civic participation is constrained by enforcement risk need frameworks for engaging government institutions without triggering adverse consequences. This requires strategic, safety-conscious, principled engagement, exactly what no comparison state has codified.	A civic education system that teaches participation pathways without addressing the structural safety constraints facing undocumented and mixed-status youth is not accessible to those students. It treats their exclusion as their problem rather than a design failure.
LGBTQIA+ Students	Students whose safety in schools is not guaranteed by existing policy environments need the capacity to organize, advocate, and navigate hostile institutional contexts without withdrawing from civic life entirely. Strategic nonviolence provides the disciplined framework for sustained civic engagement in conditions of real risk.	Without these tools, civic engagement in hostile environments requires either public exposure (and risk) or withdrawal. A civic education framework that does not provide a third path is not serving these students, it is documenting their marginalization.

Disabled Students	Students whose civic participation is structurally constrained by inaccessible civic spaces and ableist institutional designs need both the advocacy skills to name and challenge those barriers and the leadership frameworks to organize collectively with peers and families.	Without disability justice as a civic case study and without accessible participation pathways, civic education reproduces the barriers rather than equipping students to address them.
Multilingual Families	Family members who navigate civic spaces in a language other than the dominant institutional language need both the rights literacy to understand their civic standing and the strategic skills to engage meaningfully, not performatively, with school governance and community decision-making.	Without multilingual access and strategic engagement tools, family civic participation remains symbolic at best: attendance at meetings where decisions are made in inaccessible language, with no mechanism for real influence.

V. Integration in Peer Frameworks: What Exists and What Doesn't

No comparison state has codified strategic nonviolence and leadership development in statute or integrated it into a formal civic education framework. This is the strongest differentiating argument for the From Civic Learning to Civic Power proposal and the clearest evidence that Delaware has an opportunity to lead.

The closest institutional reference point is Nonviolent Schools RI, which implements the Kingian Nonviolence curriculum in Rhode Island schools as a school climate intervention with civic education applications. It is not integrated into Rhode Island's Civic Literacy Act or RIDE's Civic Learning Guidebook. The curriculum exists alongside civic education policy, not within it. Network Delaware's design challenge is to integrate what Nonviolent Schools RI has built at the program level into the architecture of a statewide civic education framework.

Illinois's Mikva Challenge and Democracy Schools program provides the closest in-framework example of organizing capacity development: students embedded in authentic campaigns and school governance structures develop civic efficacy through real influence rather than simulation. But Mikva Challenge is a partnership model, not a curriculum, and Illinois's statute does not mention nonviolence or conflict navigation explicitly.

The Rhode Island Latino Policy Institute, cited in the framework as an asset-based research reference for the Hispanic and Latino community analysis, has produced research documenting the organizing and advocacy assets of Latino communities, relevant to Front 4 curriculum design but not itself a curriculum or a civic education model.

What the comparative field shows is that Delaware must build this component through community co-design rather than adopt an off-the-shelf model. The design process matters as much as the curriculum product. A strategic nonviolence curriculum developed without the participation of the communities it is designed to serve, immigrant youth, Black and Brown youth, disabled students, LGBTQIA+ students, will not be trusted, will not be culturally relevant, and will not produce the civic efficacy outcomes the evidence base identifies as the mechanism of change.

VI. Design Requirements for Delaware's Strategic Nonviolence Curriculum

A. Process Requirements

- **Community co-design, not community consultation:** The curriculum must be developed in genuine partnership with organizations holding trust relationships with each priority community. This means decision-making authority over content, not review authority over a draft produced externally.
- **Iterative piloting with evaluation built in:** The curriculum should be piloted in at least two school-community partnership sites in the first implementation year, with

pre-designed evaluation metrics tied to civic capacity outcomes (not attendance counts), and revision cycles that reflect community feedback.

- **Educator transformation, not just educator training:** Research on both Kingian Nonviolence implementation and restorative practices implementation consistently identifies teacher belief-system transformation as a precondition for effective implementation. Professional development must be sustained, not single-session, and must be designed to shift educators' orientations toward student agency rather than student management.
- **Whole-school design, not classroom-only:** Strategic nonviolence education cannot be confined to a single course or a single teacher. It must involve school leadership commitment, family engagement, community organization partnership, and institutional policies that reflect restorative rather than punitive approaches to discipline.

B. Content Requirements

- **Power literacy:** Students must develop the capacity to analyze how power operates in the institutions that shape their lives, schools, local government, law enforcement, economic systems, and to identify points of leverage for strategic civic action.
- **Conflict navigation skills:** De-escalation techniques, principled engagement with adversarial actors, and the strategic use of nonviolent resistance as distinct from passive compliance or reactive conflict. The Kingian Nonviolence framework provides one well-developed content foundation.
- **Historical grounding in social movements:** Strategic nonviolence is not a new idea, it is the documented methodology of the Civil Rights Movement, the farmworkers movement, the disability rights movement, and the LGBTQIA+ liberation movement. Curriculum content should ground students in these histories as civic case studies, not as distant past events.
- **Leadership development as collective capacity:** Leadership in this framework is shared and transferable, not individual and positional. Curriculum must develop students' capacity to organize collectively, mentor peers, and build civic multipliers, people who carry knowledge and skills into their families and communities.
- **Safety-conscious participation pathways:** For students whose civic participation carries real risk, the curriculum must provide non-disclosure-required participation options, confidentiality protections, and engagement pathways that do not require public visibility.

VII. Network Delaware's Role

Network Delaware is positioned to serve as the coordinating entity for the strategic nonviolence curriculum co-design process in Delaware. This role has three components. First, convene: bring together the community organizations, La Esperanza, the Latin American Community Center, Equality Delaware, United Way of Delaware PRIDE Council, disability advocacy organizations, and youth-led groups, with the civic education professionals (DCCE, Delaware Civics Education Coalition) who will together develop the curriculum. Second, resource: secure the funding and professional development infrastructure necessary for piloting, drawing on the Illinois peer mentor model as the delivery mechanism and the Rhode Island civic coalition model as the process reference. Third, advocate: make the case to state policymakers that strategic nonviolence and leadership development belong in Delaware's civic education statute, not as an elective enrichment component, but as a required element of the civic preparation every Delaware student deserves.

The argument for including this component in Delaware's statutory reform is not ideological; it is empirical. The evidence base documents that civic efficacy, the mechanism of sustained civic participation, is built through authentic action in conditions that require strategy, discipline, and collective organization. For the students who need civic education most urgently, a framework that omits these elements is not incomplete; it is inadequate.

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